Instead, India's idea of a political solution, without emphasising neutrality, was taken up by Austria and West Germany on London's request (eventually categorised as the 'Austrian Model').[37] Additionally, K. R. Narayanan, a career diplomat who became India's tenth president in 1997, was sent to Washington to mend fences. Narayanan's mandate was simple: control the damage. India did not want to make the US its enemy because of Soviet misadventures. There was a need to sensitise the US about Indian concerns, and urgency to resolve the conflict. Using back channel diplomacy, India began mobilising countries at the UN to work together to influence Washington and Moscow to work out a political solution.[38] The initiative failed. By June 1980, it became clear to the Indian leadership that the Soviet presence in Afghanistan would be long-term in nature.[39] New Delhi's 'quiet diplomacy', nonetheless, began reaping tactical results. In October 1981, Gandhi met with US President Ronald Reagan in Cancun at the North-South Summit, which led to a diplomatic breakthrough.[40] Indian diplomats toned down their anti-US rhetoric and Washington stopped pressurising global institutions from cutting financial support to India. On 27 July 1982, Gandhi visited Washington after a gap of eleven years to iron out differences on Afghanistan and US arms sales to Pakistan.

Strategic failure

The three-pronged strategy, despite its tactical successes, failed to reconcile the contradictions of India's Afghanistan policy at a strategic level. Driven primarily by dependency on Moscow, Gandhi's pro-Soviet tilt put New Delhi firmly at odds with the rest of the world. For many supporters of Gandhi, aligning with the Soviet Union was a practical, if not perfect, way of respecting both India's non-aligned principle and its national security interests vis-à-vis Pakistan.[41] Such dependence on Moscow, however, became both a means and an end in itself for the Indian leadership. Even though Gandhi's relations with Moscow in the 1980s were not as warm as in the 1970s, the Soviet Union became Gandhi's political shield from adversaries both within and outside India. Domestically, Moscow supported Gandhi against the Janata Party and also neutralised radical left-wing groups such as the Communist Party of India (CPI).[42] Regionally, Soviet military